



Champions Vladimir Kramnik and Veselin Topalov) told *Sportstar* in Goa, winning the Candidates was sometimes tougher than winning the World Championship itself.

There are several routes to the Candidates, but among the most straightforward ones is the World Cup. In the Goa edition, Javokhir Sindarov of Uzbekistan, Wei Yi of China, and Andrey Esipenko of Russia claimed the honours as the three qualifiers.

Sindarov was a deserving champion. At 19, he became the youngest winner in the history of the World Cup after beating Wei in the final. He belongs to a golden generation of Uzbek chess, a group of players who could give India the biggest fight in the coming years.

The champion himself said as much shortly after his triumph. "I think India and Uzbekistan will fight for the Chess Olympiad and many other titles in the next 10 years," he said. "India has some strong young players." But none of them lived up to expectations in Goa.

In fact, there was no Indian in the semifinals. Arjun Erigaisi reached the quarterfinals all right and always looked the best of the 24 home players, but he was knocked out by

Wei. Their last-eight match was decided in the tie-breaks, after both their classical games were drawn. The 22-year-old from Warangal might have felt, in hindsight, that he could perhaps have pressed harder in the classical format.

He had begun his campaign in great style, after being seeded directly into the second round. He won his first three games back to back and had won all his matches without having to play the tie-breaks (1.5 points needed to be scored out of a possible two from the classical format) until he ran into former World No. 4 Peter Leko in the last 16.

The Hungarian took him to

Third party: Andrey Esipenko (right) beat Nodirbek Yakubboev (left) in the third-place play-off match.

MICHAL WALUSZA/FIDE

tie-breaks and then stayed on as a commentator for FIDE's official broadcast. Leko is one of the most loved commentators and was glad when people recognised him in Goa just because of his voice.

The defeat to Wei was a heartbreaking moment for Arjun: the World Cup was his only hope of making it to the Candidates. And he missed it yet again, after coming close in the past.



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